

Chapter 7

Focus

In this chapter, we discuss the importance of knowing how to establish, hold, shift, and deepen the focus. We use the term *focus* primarily as a noun to refer to what is happening in the group. At any given moment in a session, the focus is either on a *topic* (love relationships, ways of dealing with parents, trust within the group), an *activity* (guided fantasy, a written exercise, blind trust walk), or a *person* (member talking about personal conflicts, fears, concerns, issues, or problems). Throughout a session, the leader establishes the focus on certain topics, activities, or individuals; holds the focus; or shifts the focus. The leader should always be aware of the depth of any discussion or personal work and should, when appropriate, try to deepen the focus. The skilled leader understands that the focus moves from person to person and topic to topic, and it is the leader who is responsible for making sure the focus goes with the purpose of the group. *Knowing how to establish, hold, shift, and deepen the focus is essential for good leadership.*

Establishing the Focus

There are many different ways to establish focus in a group. The important thing to understand is that the leader is usually the person who establishes the focus. The following sections highlight several ways in which the leader can establish the focus. They are use of comments, use of activities and exercises, and use of rounds and dyads.

Use of Comments to Establish the Focus

Often, the leader can establish the focus by stating to the members what the topic or activity is going to be for the next few minutes.

- Let's focus on the topic of guilt for the next hour.
- Let's focus on Julio for the next 10–15 minutes and try to help him with his dilemma.
- I'd like us to summarize what this last 30 minutes has meant.
- Let's really zero in on one of these topics. It doesn't matter which one, but let's pick one rather than trying to talk about all three.
- The topic for tonight is learning how to budget your time. Who wants to share what they learned from the reading on time management?

Use of Activities and Exercises to Establish the Focus

Using visual aids and having members write or draw something are excellent ways to get members focused. The following are just a few examples of activities that can be used to establish the focus.

1. *Use posters, charts, or diagrams relevant to the topic or task of the group.* Visual aids get the members involved both visually and auditorily.
2. *Use a whiteboard or a large pad to list items or characteristics.* For instance, if the group members are talking about drugs, the leader can go to the board and say, "Let's list the pros and cons of drug use." In a school group, the leader can say, "Let's list the characteristics of a good friend." While looking at the list on the board, members often get more focused by trying to generate new items to add.
3. *Use a whiteboard to draw pictures or visual analogies.* For example, group members could be discussing all the ways they feel they are being held down. The leader could go to the board (or a large flip chart) and sketch a large hot-air balloon with various lead weights hanging off the sides. Each weight would be labeled in terms of pounds (200, 100, 50, 25, 10), and there would be space under each to fill in what that weight represented. This image might prove helpful to members and allow them to focus on what is holding them down and to what degree. Another drawing might be of a road with various roadblocks and choices on it. Having a drawing in front of the members often helps them focus on a topic.
4. *Have members list or write something.* A very helpful focusing technique is to have members write answers on sentence-completion forms. For example, a leader who wants the group to focus on the topic of parents could make up a list of five sentences for members to complete. It might look something like the following:

When I think of my mom, I _____.
When I think of my dad, I _____.
I wish my dad _____.
I wish my mom _____.
The biggest problem I have with my parents is _____.

Another focusing technique that involves writing is to have each member make a list of something. For instance, the leader could have a group of first-year college students list their worries or have elementary school children list their favorite activities.

5. *Have members draw something.* Drawing such things as their favorite scene, the house they grew up in, or their earliest memory helps members focus on topics such as "what I like and value," "what my family was like," and the impact of childhood on present-day living.
6. *Put a large piece of paper on the floor in the center of the group with a stimulus word or phrase on it.* With this phrase in the center of the floor to stare at, members usually stay focused. Some examples of words and phrases that you might put in the middle of the group are Dad, Mom, work, responsibilities, fears I have, changes I can make in my life, and things I enjoy.
7. *Use handouts that contain information you want to cover.* Handouts give members something to look at and relate to. Also, members can take them with when the session is over.
8. *Place an empty chair in the center of the room.* The empty chair can represent different people. If the leader wants to focus on parents, she can have the chair represent one or both parents. If she wants to focus on anger, she can have the chair be someone with whom the members are angry.
9. *Stand on a chair.* The leader can usually focus members on such issues as need for approval or codependency by standing on an empty chair and asking a few questions about the people that the members have "above" them.
10. *Place a small child's chair in the center of the room.* The small chair can represent the free child, the inner child, or the hurt child. By having the chair present, members tend to focus on that part of themselves much more easily than if simply asked to imagine being the child.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Getting the Focus

Watch video 10.2 for a demonstration of using the small chair to focus members.

Other creative techniques include the use of shields, beer bottles, rubber bands, and videotapes. For a complete description of these and other creative

techniques, see *Impact Therapy: The Courage to Counsel* (Jacobs & Schimmel, 2013), a book that encourages counselors to be creative and innovative when counseling individuals and groups.

When used properly, all these techniques can prove very helpful to the leader. There are many direct and creative ways to establish group focus, and it is important to have a number of techniques to choose from. Different situations call for different techniques; through trial and error and experience, you will learn which ones work best in particular situations.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Getting the Focus

Watch video 7.1 for a discussion of focus and a demonstration of using a creative technique to establish focus.

Use of Rounds and Dyads to Establish the Focus

Rounds and dyads are two additional ways to establish the focus. *Rounds* are very useful because they involve everybody and focus members by having them think of what they are going to say. Below are a few examples of how rounds can be used to establish the focus.

- Think of what has been the biggest change since your accident. In a minute, I'm going to have each of you comment briefly on this.
- How much effect do your siblings have on you today—a lot, a little, or none? Think about this, and then we'll do a round and hear from each of you.
- In a word or a phrase, what stood out to you the most about tonight?

Dyads help focus members on a topic because members are paired with one another and instructed to discuss various ideas. The following examples illustrate how dyads can be used to get members to focus on certain issues.

- Pair up and talk about ways you can benefit from the group.
- Pair up and talk about your reaction to the reading for the week.

Holding the Focus

Once the leader has the group focused, knowing how to *hold* the focus is essential. The leader is constantly deciding if she should hold the focus or shift it to some other person, topic, or activity. Holding the focus means sticking with what is currently happening. For example, if Mac is discussing the pain he's experiencing over his wife's death and Melvin interrupts and begins discussing

his brother's visit, the leader holds the focus by directing the group back to Mac. If members of a group are discussing feelings of insecurity regarding dating and someone asks a question about the five best places to go with a date, the trained leader does not let the topic shift to "places to go" but rather holds the focus on insecurities. There are three considerations to keep in mind for holding the focus: when to hold it, how long to hold it, and how to hold it.

When to Hold the Focus

Focus on a Topic The following questions are helpful in determining whether to hold the focus on a topic. (By *topic*, we mean such things as parents, vanity, the value of staying in school, how to budget money, or any other subject the group is discussing.)

- Is the topic relevant to the purpose of the group? If it is not relevant to the purpose, usually the leader will want to shift the focus to a more relevant topic.
- Are the members interested in the topic? If most members are not interested, the leader will probably want to shift the focus, although there are times when the leader may decide to stay with it a little longer.
- Has the focus been on the topic too long? This usually depends on how much the leader planned to cover in the session. If there are five major issues to discuss and the group is still on the first one with only half the session remaining, the focus should probably be shifted.
- Has the group discussed the topic before? Sometimes a group will go over the same issues week after week. If that topic is becoming redundant and there seems to be little energy for that topic, an effective leader will shift the focus.

The answers to these questions will give leaders a sense of whether to hold or shift the focus. When the leader is unsure about whether to stay with a topic, doing a "quick 1–10" will help to decide. The leader can say, "I want to get a quick reading from you on whether we should continue to discuss the issue of ___. On a 1–10 scale, with 10 being *very interested* and 1 being *very disinterested,* what number best describes your attitude?" Usually the numbers will indicate whether there is enough interest. If all are low numbers or high numbers, the decision is obvious.

If there is a range, a number of things can be done. The leader may ask those who indicated high interest what they specifically would like to discuss and then focus the group there with a time limit of 5, 10, or 20 minutes. She could split the group and let those with high interest meet for 20 minutes (depending on the time remaining) while the others discuss another topic. Splitting the group is appropriate only in educational or discussion groups where group cohesion is not a major goal. Leaders rarely do this in a growth or therapy group. The leader can also give a break to those who rated their interest as low while the high-interest members continue with the topic. As you can see, the

quick 1–10 round can offer information that generates a number of options for the leader.

Focus on a Person In any group, the focus can easily center on one person. When this happens, it is the leader who decides whether to hold the focus on the person or to shift it to another person or to a topic. The leader must consider a number of things when making this decision.

Does focusing on one person serve the purpose of the group? Some groups meet for the purpose of doing therapy or personal growth work; in such groups, focusing on one person is appropriate. Other groups meet for discussion, sharing, or accomplishing a task; thus, to focus on one person would be inappropriate.

Is the person benefiting from having the focus? If the person is benefiting and most of the other members are also, then the leader would want to hold the focus. If the person is benefiting but most of the other members are not, then the decision to hold the focus is more difficult. Rarely will the leader want to hold the focus when only one or two members are involved in what is being said. If the leader cannot engage most of the members in the working member's work, he may decide to meet with the person individually because the issue is not one to which the other members can relate.

Who is talking, and how much "air time" has the speaker had recently? If the person talking has not spoken in a while or has spoken very little throughout the group's life, it is usually beneficial to hold the focus on that individual. On the other hand, if the person has had the group's attention often in the past, the leader may choose to shift the focus.

How Long to Hold the Focus

One question you may be asking is, How long is the focus held on a person or topic? There is no single answer because it depends on the purpose of the group, which session it is, what happened in the previous sessions, and how much time is left in the current session. Also, different factors must be considered, depending on whether the focus is on a topic or on a person.

Focus on a Topic How long to hold the focus on a topic depends on a number of things. If the group is an education, discussion, or task group where there are a number of things to be covered, the leader will want to budget the time wisely. Many beginning leaders get so caught up in the content or interaction that they forget that other topics need to be covered. Also, leaders have to be aware when interest in the topic is waning. It is usually best to shift the focus to another topic before the majority of the members get bored and tune out the group.

Focusing on a heavy issue in the early stages of a group is usually not wise. Also, the leader should not focus on topics such as sex or death unless there is ample time to discuss them. A discussion of death can stir up a

number of feelings, memories, and fears, so it is probably wise not to hold the focus on death if it comes up during the last 30 minutes of the session. The leader would probably want to say something like, "Let's hold off discussing the topic of death until next week because we really don't have enough time to fully discuss it, and I wouldn't want us to get started on something that might leave some of you hanging."

Focus on a Person The amount of time to hold the focus on a person depends partly on the kind of group being led. For therapy, growth, and support groups, where holding the focus on one person is appropriate, the upper limit is probably 30 minutes. Naturally, there will be exceptions: Sometimes the leader may stay with one person for an hour or more; however, this should be the exception rather than the rule. In most therapy, growth, and support groups, the usual amount of time is between 5 and 15 minutes. In other kinds of groups (discussion, education, or task), a good rule of thumb would be not to hold the focus longer than 5 minutes on any one person, because you would probably want an exchange of ideas or information from all the members.

Holding the focus for a long period also depends on which session it is. Leaders do not want anyone to dominate the first couple of sessions because the goal is to get people to feel comfortable being in the group. If one person dominates, other members tend to sit back and listen rather than think and contribute. Beginning leaders often make the mistake of focusing for too long on one member in early sessions because of their own nervousness or their lack of cutting-off and drawing-out skills.

How to Hold the Focus

When the group is flowing and the focus starts to shift, the leader has access to several skills and methods for holding the focus. The main skill is cutting members off. (See Chapter 8 for a complete discussion.) Whether you are using that skill or one of the methods described next, remember that the most important thing is to *act quickly*. The longer you wait before bringing the group back to the topic or person, the harder it will be, because the members' energy and attention will have become invested in the new person or topic. The most common method for holding the focus is to address the group directly.

- Let's stay with Sandy.
- I want to go back to what Joe was saying. Joe, when did you start feeling that way?
- Can we put that on hold until Karen finishes with her list?
- I believe we may have left Manuel, and I think we need to stay with him a little longer—Manuel, do you want to say more about that situation?
- Let's finish this topic before we start a new one.
- I think if we're not careful, we'll get too many things going at once—let's go back to the topic of _____.

If you decide that you want the group to stay with a certain topic or person for a while, it is sometimes helpful to verbalize this. For example, if your group has been discussing aspects of daily living, you might say, "Let's spend the next 10 minutes talking only about what is difficult for you on a daily basis."

Another way to hold the focus is to conduct a group exercise or use a prop. For instance, if the members were discussing their fears about cancer and the focus shifted to financial concerns, the leader could bring them back to the topic of fears by saying, "I'd like to list the different fears that you are experiencing *(Stands and goes to the board)*. Financial fear is one; what are some others?" Or imagine a task group where eight members are trying to resolve their differences on how the probation office and welfare office can work together. The discussion has turned momentarily to a local judge and how her recent rulings have been inconsistent. Seeing the need to hold the focus on the task, the leader could say to the members, "I'd like to do something a little different. I want each of you to pair up with someone from the other office and come up with a list of suggestions for improving the working relationship of your two offices."

The possible techniques for holding the focus are actually unlimited. With experience, you will develop more techniques. Until then, try to use some of the ideas provided, plus others you will learn later in this book.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Holding the Focus

Watch video 7.2 for a demonstration of the leader holding the focus. You will also see holding the focus demonstrated in many other videos.

Shifting the Focus

Although holding the focus and shifting the focus are very much tied together, it is important to conceptualize them as separate skills. Leaders consciously shift the focus when they decide that there is a need for a change in the group. The shift can go in any of the following directions:

- From a topic to a person
- From a topic to another topic
- From a topic to an activity
- From a person to another person
- From a person to a topic
- From a person to an activity
- From an activity to a topic
- From an activity to a person

It is important to notice that "from an activity to another activity" is not listed because this kind of focus shift is usually not appropriate. *One of the biggest mistakes that beginning leaders make is to conduct one activity after another.* Group exercises need to be followed by discussion and not just conducted one after the next. We discuss conducting group exercises in Chapter 11.

When to Shift the Focus

There are two main ways to conceptualize shifting the focus: (1) as a shift *away* from some person, topic, or activity, or (2) as a shift *to* some person, topic, or activity. The leader may shift the focus in any of the following situations:

- The focus has been on one person for too long.
- The focus has been on one topic for too long.
- The focus does not fit the purpose of the group.
- The time left dictates the need for change.
- The leader feels the members need a change to re-energize the group.
- The leader wants to draw another member into the group.
- The leader wants to introduce a new topic or activity.

Shift from a Topic to a Person Leaders often want to shift the focus from a topic to a person in counseling, therapy, and growth groups, but may do so in all kinds of groups.

EXAMPLES

The group has been discussing jealousy, and a number of members have commented on how they handle it. The discussion has been going on for 3 to 4 minutes. The leader decides to focus on one person. Here are two ways the focus can be shifted to a person.

MISSY: I just can't help it—I'm a jealous person. If Frank is talking to some woman at a party, I lose it.

BILL: But why? My wife does that to me, too. I don't like it at all.

TED: I'm a lot more jealous than my wife. In fact, I don't think she gets jealous, and that makes me mad sometimes!

LEADER: Missy, I'm wondering if you would want to explore your jealousy further. You seem to be bothered by it, and I think I detect a desire on your part to get better control of it.

Using this same example, the leader merely indicates the desire to shift to a person but does not focus on any one individual.

Leader: Would anyone like to spend a few minutes talking specifically about his or her concerns with jealousy? It is apparent to me that many of you are concerned about it. Ted, you and Missy and Bill all have talked about how jealousy is interfering in your relationships.



The following examples are additional comments that leaders can make to shift to a person:

- I'd like each of you to think about what we have been talking about for the last few minutes. Does anybody want to work on anything regarding this issue?
- Who wants to take this issue deeper? There seem to be several things that you could work on.
- This discussion is good; however, I feel that some of you may have something personal that you want to discuss. Does anyone have something you would like to bring up?

In the last example, the shift would not only be to a person but possibly to a new topic. If the leader doesn't want the topic to shift, a comment like the first example, which is more specific, should be used.

Shift from One Topic to Another In discussion, task, and education groups, the leader will usually need to shift the focus to cover the necessary material or accomplish the task. To shift the focus, the leader might say any of the following:

- Let's take a minute or two to finish this topic because we need to move on to something else.
- We seem to be about finished with this issue. Who has some other issues or points to bring up?
- We have a lot to cover tonight, so let's go on to something else.
- I would like to change the discussion to focus on what Kay was talking about. She mentioned the effects of the decision. Let's talk about what the rest of you think the effects would be.

In task groups and education groups, there is often specific material to be covered. The leader can help shift the focus by letting the members know the agenda and an estimate of the time needed to cover the topics. For example, the leader could say the following:

- Today, we are going to talk about diet and exercise as they relate to stress. We'll spend approximately 45 minutes on each topic.
- First, we need to decide which proposal we want to accept. Then we need to decide who will do what and discuss the necessary schedule

changes that will be required. We have only an hour and a half, so we'll need to watch the time.

In each of these examples, telling the members what the agenda is helps the leader. It is still the leader's responsibility to budget the group's time and to shift the focus when needed, but the clock can be used to do so—that is, by allowing a specified number of minutes for each topic. When the time has run out, the leader can say to the group, "We need to move on because of time." Following are some additional ways that leaders can shift to a new topic:

- We have a lot to cover today, so let's move on to the next chapter.
- Let's turn to another issue that is equally as important as the one we are now discussing.
- There are two more topics that we need to cover today. Let me throw them out to you, and then let's decide which one we want to do next.

Shift from a Topic to an Exercise Often, when the group is discussing a topic, a group exercise may be useful to further the discussion or involve more members. The leader introduces the exercise by saying something like, "I want us to stay with what we are discussing, but I think an exercise could be helpful now." Or the leader can say, "I want to change the format a little bit. There is a group exercise that fits in with what we are talking about." Leaders often use a round exercise to shift from a topic. For instance, if the group has been discussing a topic for some time, the leader might say, "In a word or phrase, what are you thinking about right now? Let's do a round and hear from everyone." Another round that leaders use after a discussion is, "What are two things that stood out to you? We'll quickly go around the room and hear from each of you." Another easy way to shift from a topic to an activity is to have members form dyads to further discuss the topic that was being explored in the large group.

Shift from One Person to Another Person If the leader has determined that the focus needs to shift to another person, there are a number of possible things to say. Following are some examples of different situations and different responses:

- Lori, I think it would be good to let you just think about what you have been saying these last 15 minutes; then maybe we'll come back to you later on. What did this bring up for the rest of you? Who wants to explore their reactions or feelings?
- Joe, I'd like to shift to Cindy. (The leader turns and addresses Cindy.) You seem to really be relating to this. I noticed a couple of times that you wanted to say something. Do you want to share that now?
- Avid, we'll stay with you for another couple of minutes; then I'm going to give others a chance to share their ideas.

In these examples the leader addresses the person who has the focus and then shifts it. The leader who wants to cut off the member who has the focus will address the group directly. In such situations, the leader might say something like this:

- Does anyone want to comment on what Joe has been saying?
- Let's not focus on John, but rather on you. Any thoughts or feelings?
- Cindy, how about you? You seem deep in thought.
- Can anyone relate to what Lori has been saying? *(The leader would look away from Lori and would have some idea of who might want to speak.)*

Shift from a Person to a Topic There are times when a leader wants to focus on the topic that a person is addressing. This may be because the topic is one that he thinks is relevant for most of the members or because he wants to subtly shift the focus from the member who currently has it. The following examples illustrate this:

- Dean, I want to pick up on what you've been talking about. I think the issue is a good one, and I want to hear how others think and feel about it. What do others of you think about the issue—how do you deal with it and what reactions have you received? *(Throwing out so many different questions invites discussion, which in this case is the intention.)*
- Carol, you have brought up many concerns that certainly others can relate to. I'd like to spend the rest of the session discussing some of those issues. Let's take the one you mentioned first. *(Mentioning Carol by name and using some of the content she has been discussing increases the likelihood that she will not feel cut off.)*
- Julio, your thoughts are interesting. However, I am aware that we are running out of time, and we still have one more major item to discuss. Why don't you summarize your position, and then we will move on.
- I want to shift the discussion to the whole group because we really want to hear a number of ideas and views. What do the rest of you think?

Shift from a Person to an Exercise As mentioned earlier, the leader can use a round as a very good way to shift the focus; that is, ask members to rate on a 1–10 scale or give a word or phrase about some subject. Also, the leader can simply ask the members to pair up and discuss what the member has been talking about, or to talk about any thoughts or feelings they had when the member was speaking. Many other group exercises can be used to shift the focus. The following ways can introduce such exercises:

- I want to take what you are talking about and get the whole group to think about it. Everyone get out a piece of paper and something to write with. I want you to do the following....

- Ruth, your energy and enthusiasm are appreciated. I want to see if I can get everyone as excited and interested as you are. Everyone stand up—I want you to move to this side of the room. Now, here's what I want you to do.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Shifting the Focus

Watch videos 7.3 and 7.4 for demonstrations of a leader shifting focus.

Deepening the Focus

A leader thinks not only of holding or shifting the focus but also whether or not to deepen the focus. *The key to most groups is deepening the focus to a level that is productive and meaningful for the members.* In many groups, members have a tendency to get sidetracked or avoid delving too deeply into their issues. Therefore, it is the leader's responsibility to make sure the group "funnels" to a meaningful depth. Depth is measured differently for various groups—for education and discussion groups, depth is measured by assessing learning and the exchange of ideas. Task-group depth is measured by productivity and how well members are working together. Counseling, therapy, growth, and support groups are measured by new insights about living and belonging, and the level of sharing when doing personal work. A leader deepens the focus by using the following techniques:

- Asking very thought-provoking or challenging questions
- Asking members to share at a more personal level
- Working with a member in a more intense manner
- Conducting an intense exercise that gets in touch with some deep, personal issues
- Confronting members about certain dynamics that are interfering with the group

EXAMPLES

MOLLY: I think everyone gets angry at their partners.

ED: Sonja and I fight at least once a week.

TONI: I said I didn't want to fight like my parents, but we do.

LEADER: Wait just a minute. I want all of you to really think about what you are saying. Do you really believe you have to fight? I absolutely don't agree with that. Many couples do fight, but they don't have to.

I would bet if you look at your fights with your partner, you will see some unhealthy patterns, lots of expectations not in line with reality, and lots of unfinished business from childhood or former relationships.

Ed: *(After a minute or so of silence)* I hate to say it, but you are right. I want Sonja to be like my first wife was, and she is not. That's what most of our fights are about.

Leader: Would you like to explore that further?

Ed: Yes, I think so.

Leader: Let's hear from others and then we'll come back to you, Ed.

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Karen: I think the government should spend more on research for medical cures than sending all the foreign aid to other countries.

Cynthia: I heard that the drug companies are partly the reason why they don't find cures because it would put them out of business.

Leader: Let's not worry about the politics of finding a cure. Our time can be much better spent sharing personal thoughts and feelings about your disease. What feelings have you had this week?

Connie: I sometimes wake up so scared, I can't go back to sleep.

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Leader: I want to bring up something I noticed. Many of you have things on your mind because you have shared them in your diaries or in individual meetings with me, but no one shares in the group. There is something holding you back. I know this can be a good experience for most, if not all, of you if we can just figure out what is going on. Think about it. I want us to discuss what keeps you from sharing. Any thoughts?

Juan: I think I know some of why I hold back.

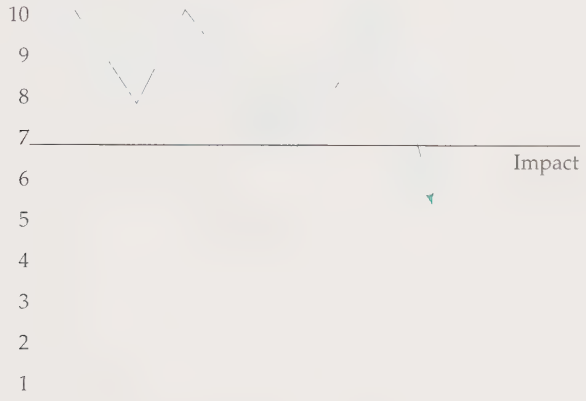
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In each example, the leader made a comment or asked a question to deepen the focus. Many less skilled leaders let the group members take the group where they want it to go, which often results in the group not going to a deeper level.

Depth Chart

To discuss the depth of the group in a concrete way, we have devised the *depth chart.* The depth chart is a 10–1 scale, with a 10 representing surface-level talking or sharing, and a 1 representing deep, intense, personal sharing. During the life of

a group, the depth of discussion will vary. In the beginning phase, the depth is usually a 10 or 9 because members are telling stories or talking superficially about some topic or issue. As a group moves to the middle phase, the depth should reach below 8 to at least a 7; and for most groups, the leader will want the group to reach a depth of 6 or below. Too often, groups bounce from topic to topic and never go deep enough to derive any benefit, following a pattern of 10, 9, 8; new topic 10, 9, 8; new topic, 10, 9, 8. In the chart, the interaction of a group is depicted: One topic went to an 8, then a new topic started and went to a 7, and then a third topic was started and went to a 5.



By using a depth chart, a leader can better visualize and understand what is happening in the group. In most groups, the desired depth during the working phase is 6 or deeper, with some groups going to an intense level of 3, 2, or even 1. If the group is staying at the 10, 9, 8 level, the leader needs to intensify the discussion. The leader may want to funnel to a deeper level by using an exercise that encourages members to explore an issue in greater depth. Processing the exercise can lead to discussion or individual work at a level of 6 or lower. In some groups, the leader may draw or explain the depth chart and periodically ask the members how they would chart the discussions and interactions within the group.

When to Deepen the Focus

There are two considerations when thinking of deepening the focus. The first is the phase of the session, because deepening the focus should be done only during the middle phase of a group, not during the warm-up or the ending phases. When there is an opportunity to deepen the focus during the middle phase, the leader should also consider if there is enough time to adequately cover the issue or topic. Beginning leaders often will deepen the focus and then run out of time and leave members hanging—this is not good leadership.

How Deep to Focus

There are a number of considerations regarding how deep to focus a group. The most important consideration is the purpose of the group. Too often in education, discussion, and task groups, leaders mistakenly deepen the focus on individuals. This makes members uncomfortable and can be harmful, because members did not expect or even agree to a therapy group; and, yet, all of a sudden, that is what is happening. *Always consider the purpose of the group before deepening the focus to a very personal, intense level.*

Even if the members are open to going to a deeper level, it is always advisable for a leader to think about the members and the appropriate depth. For most school groups, especially elementary groups, leaders should not want personal sharing to be below a 4. The leader always should consider whether a member can handle sharing personal concerns or receiving feedback in the group. Members differ in the degree to which they are ready and comfortable to share and receive feedback and can be harmed if they are not able to deal with what is being said. Too often, beginning leaders get so involved in the process that they forget to consider if certain members are ready and able to deal with the depth to which the group is heading.

EXAMPLE

The leader of this group of elementary kids stops the focus from going deeper, because he sensed that the member was going to get into some serious abuse issues that would not be appropriate for the other members to hear.

ELAINE: My dad isn't mean exactly, but he does make me do things I don't want to do.

MEMBERS: Like what?

ELAINE: (Head hanging down, in a sad voice) Not nice things.

MEMBERS: What?

LEADER: You know, Elaine, I think this may be something you and I can talk about privately. Does anyone else want to talk about fights you are having with your parents?

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There are two other considerations regarding the depth of focus: The first has to do with expertise and the second with multicultural concerns. Sometimes in groups, issues come up that the leader may know little about. It is unethical to push a member into deeper work when the leader does not have the experience, knowledge, and understanding to deal with the problem. Too often, we hear of unqualified leaders dealing with some very intense therapy issues. Regarding multicultural concerns, any leader must consider the cultural background before delving too deeply and too quickly with a group member, because some

members may be very uncomfortable. It is very important to get a contract with the member before pushing him into deeper work.

EXAMPLE

Here the leader makes sure the member wants to work on the issue she is struggling with. The leader uses another member to help deepen the focus.

DASHA: Ever since coming to this country, I have been confused about my role as a woman. Here, things are very different. I get a point of view from this group that clashes with everything I was taught in my country.

SUSAN: But you live here and are planning to stay here. We will support you. That's what the group is for.

LEADER: *(Interrupts with a kind, warm voice)* Wait a minute here. Dasha, I want you to tell us how we can be of help. Certainly, we want to respect what you learned from your country, and at the same time, we want to be of help and not confuse you. Do you think the group can be helpful to you right now and if so, how?

DASHA: I do think you can help by helping me get over feeling like I am doing something wrong.

LEADER: *(Deciding to hold the focus on Dasha and try to deepen it)* I think we can do that. Have any of you made changes in your life where you went against your upbringing?

ELIE: My decision to come to this country went against everything I'd been taught. I struggled with the pain I caused my family.

DASHA: How did you get the strength to do what you believed was right for you?

ELIE: I had to trust myself—after much soul-searching, I might add.

DASHA: *(With a thoughtful voice)* I have to learn this. I do have to learn to trust myself. I can see most of you are happy and I am not. I have to come to believe that I have a right to be happy.

LEADER: Would it help to tell us about your culture and what you were taught?

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GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Deepening the Focus

Watch videos 7.5 and 7.6 for demonstrations of a leader deepening the focus. In 7.5 the focus is deepened on a person. In video 7.6, watch how the leader deepens the focus on a topic. You will also see this skill demonstrated in many other videos (10.2, 14.1, 14.2, 14.3).

Concluding Comments

A good leader understands that paying attention to the focus is one of the most important skills of group leading. There are many different techniques for establishing, holding, shifting, and deepening the focus. The focus of a group is always either on a person, topic, or activity. To maintain control over what is happening in the group, the leader should be aware of where the focus is and whether it needs to be shifted or held. The leader also must be aware of how deep the session is and may use a depth chart to monitor the development of a session. Before deepening the focus, the leader should consider the purpose of the group, the stage of the group, the phase of the session, the amount of time left, and how deep to focus the group.

In Chapters 2 and 3, we introduced concepts that, along with the focus, serve as maps for understanding the interactions and development of a group. Because these maps are so useful when leading groups, we summarize them here to show how the four go together.

- Purpose: Why the group is meeting
- Stage: Where the group is in its development (beginning, middle, ending)
- Phase: Where the session is (warm-up, working, closing)
- Focus: The content of the group (establishing, holding, shifting, and deepening the focus)

ACTIVITIES

1. Next time you are in a group, class, or among friends, observe how the focus is on either a topic, person, or activity. Also observe how the focus is either holding or shifting. If appropriate, using comments or questions, consciously shift or hold the focus and, if possible, deepen the focus.
2. Using the depth chart idea, observe the depth of a discussion with a group of people. Try to give numbers, using the 10–1 scale *(10 being surface talk)*. If the group is not going below 7, try to deepen the focus by asking a thought-provoking question or by making an insightful statement.
3. Think of a group you might lead. Set a purpose and then a topic that is appropriate. Think of three different ways you could deepen the focus on the topic you have chosen.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. Review videos 7.1–7.6.
   a. Think about the importance of using the skills of getting, holding, shifting, and deepening the focus.

b. Imagine how these groups would have gone differently if the leader had not been using the skills of holding, shifting, and deepening the focus.

2. Review the first two segments of the videos—The Leader Without Skills (1.1) and The Leader with Skills (1.2)—and note the difference in regards to the leader's skills in holding and shifting of the focus.
3. Watch video 14.3 and observe how the focus is held on a topic (forgiving yourself) and a person (the woman whose father abused her). Also watch the leader briefly hold focus on one member who had voted for herself, since he knew it would only take a few minutes, and then return to the heavier issues.